



Long journey: Vikram Rathour, the former India and Punjab wicketkeeper-batter, was appointed to the post of batting coach in 2019. R. V. MOORTHY

player is not true. There were a few players who could have done better.

How has the approach to T20 batting changed?

When I joined, we batted using a traditional method. We batted with an anchor who looked to bat deep with the tail around him. We were lagging behind the other teams. We had to play with more intent throughout the innings. It changed in the last two World Cups. We didn't have someone who could bat at No. 8 in the previous World Cup because of the injury to Ravindra Jadeja. You have to have a decent No. 9 who can bat. This time, we had Axar Patel in that position. That gave a lot of freedom to the batters, even though the conditions were not favourable. That's the new template. We are playing more aggressive cricket and looking to score par-plus every time.

The approach to Test batting has changed, too. We hardly see matches lasting five days. Do you

think defensive batsmanship to save a game is a relic of the past?

Yes. There are two reasons: the emergence of T20 and white-ball cricket. People are batting differently. Batters are playing more positively and taking more risks, so wickets also fall more regularly. The Test Championship has contributed, too. Every team wants to win to earn points. You are batting on more challenging pitches, with the home team wanting to win. A draw is in nobody's interest. You look to win every game. I can only see a few draws happening in the future.

Rohit has refined his white-ball game over the last two years.

What sort of work went into changing his intent at the top?

It was his thinking. As captain, he extensively discussed adding more aggression to our batting approach. The character that he is, Rohit, is keen to lead the fight from the front. Rather than telling others to do it, he wanted to do it himself. And he did

that. He has been phenomenal with his batting approach. It rubbed off on others, too. They were inspired by what the leader was doing. He did not hold back, even when he failed, at times, and it helped the team.

India enjoyed some great Test success overseas during your tenure...

We became a successful team overseas due to our bowling unit. The bowlers started picking up more wickets. The change began when Virat and Ravi (Shastri) were together. They decided to always play with five bowlers. As a batting group, we prepared better. This generation is better equipped to deal with fast bowlers and short bowling.

We also saw a transition, with senior pros like Cheteshwar Pujara and Ajinkya Rahane giving way to juniors. How did you go about this process?

Both of them had done well for a long time, but then you have such